

Shrimad Bhagavad Gita

JANA KIDHAR HAI

Part 1

Maharshi Ved Vyasa

Translated with Commentary by

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Preface

श्रीमद्भगवद्गीता जाना किधर है – भाग 1

In the minds of many people, there exists a deep-rooted belief that the Mahabharata should neither be read nor kept at home. However, in the first chapter of the Mahabharata, a verse declares:

ब्रह्मन् वेदरहस्यं च यच्चान्यत् स्थापितं मया ।

साङ्गोपनिषदां चैव वेदानां विस्तरक्रिया ॥

brahman vedarahasyam ca yac cānyat

sthāpitam mayā |

*sāṅgopaniṣadāṁ caiva vedānāṁ vistara-
kriyā || 62 ||*

*When Sage Vyasa, through his divine vision,
perceived the entirety of this epic, he
addressed Lord Brahma, the creator of the
universe, saying that within this single
composition, he had gathered the hidden
essence of the Vedas, the wisdom of the
Upanishads along with all their branches, and
the substance of other sacred scriptures.
Indeed, this was no exaggeration. The
Mahabharata is a scripture that encompasses
everything.*

*It contains the essence of the Puranas, the
Vedas, and the Upanishads, along with its own*

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*grand narrative. The sacred Bhagavad Gita
forms a part of it. The divine leelas (divine play)
of Krishna are described within it. The spirit and
summary of the Ramayana are also found in its
pages. It speaks of the origin of creation, of
medicine, charity, education, justice,
pilgrimage, oceans, death, disease, fear, old
age, and of the past, present, and future.
Understanding its profound meaning, this great
epic was written down by Ganesha as Vyasa
dictated it. Sage Vyasa composed it for the
welfare of sorrow-stricken humanity, so that
their suffering might be alleviated.*

Further, it is said:

*श्रद्धानः सदा युक्तः सदा धर्मपरायणः ।
आसेवन्निममध्यायं नरः पापात् प्रमुच्यते ॥
śraddadhānaḥ sadā yuktaḥ sadā*

dharmaparāyaṇaḥ |
āsevan imam adhyāyaṁ naraḥ pāpāt
pramucyate || 261 ||

In this verse, it is clearly stated that a person who has faith, who remains devoted to

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righteousness, and who regularly studies the Gita's chapters becomes freed from all sins. Even when difficulties arise, such a person remains untouched by sorrow. It is also declared that one who recites it in the morning, at noon, or in the evening attains freedom from sin, and gets a long life, honor, and lasting fame.

It is written that once the gods assembled and placed the four Vedas on one side of a scale and the Mahabharata on the other; the Mahabharata proved heavier. Therefore, without any doubt or hesitation, it should be kept at home and read daily. The Bhagavad Gita is not meant merely to be read—it is meant to be experienced. Only then does its true mystery unfold.

Yes, for a long time, this nectar of wisdom was kept away from us. Why? That remains a subject worthy of reflection.

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The Mahabharata in Brief

When Sage Vyasa Narrated the Epic

The Mahabharata is a blazing lamp in the history of India. It is the greatest epic of Aryan civilization and the eternal tradition of Hindu

culture. The great sage, the righteous Vyasa, with his vision of knowledge, first perceived this epic as though witnessing it directly, while seated in a cave in the Himalayas, and then resolved to compose it. For this purpose, he sought counsel from Brahma, the creator of the

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universe, asking: “How may I spread this most revered epic throughout all the worlds? How shall I teach it to my disciples? In this great epic, I have elaborated not only the essence of all the Vedas, but also their auxiliary disciplines and the Upanishads.”

Thereupon, Brahma Himself appeared before Vyasa and said, “Vyasa, since you have called this work a poetic composition, it shall be known as the first great poetic creation of this universe. Therefore, your composition will be renowned as an epic. No one in the world will be able to create a work greater than this. To have this epic written down, invoke Ganesha.” Having said this, Brahma departed. Then, the revered Sage Vyasa invoked Ganesha. When Ganesha agreed to write, Vyasa began to dictate complex and profound verses, for Ganesha had laid down a condition: “If you are unable to dictate the next verse immediately after I finish writing the previous one, I will stop writing.” Vyasa, in turn, placed his own condition: “You must write each verse only after fully understanding it.”

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According to the Mahabharata tradition, Vyasa

composed 8,800 such verses whose meanings were understood only by Vyasa, his son the Sage Shukadeva, and Ganesha. At times, when Ganesha paused for a moment to grasp the deeper meaning of a verse, Vyasa would, in that very interval, compose several more verses in his mind. After attaining divine vision, Sanjaya—the one who narrated the entire Mahabharata to King Dhritarashtra—whether he fully comprehended the meanings of these 8,800 cryptic verses or not is questioned in verses 81–82 of the First Chapter of the Mahabharata itself. These verses are woven with such intricate depth that their mysteries cannot be easily unraveled.

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Background

In northern India, there was a region known as the Kuru realm. In its royal palace lived a valiant warrior named Bhishma, the protector of the Kuru dynasty and its most senior member. For the welfare of the kingdom, he had taken a solemn vow never to marry. In time, this vow also became one of the major causes of the Mahabharata war. He was the eldest member of the royal household. He was the son of King Shantanu and Mother Ganga.

King Shantanu often went into the forest to hunt fierce animals. One day, there he beheld a woman of incomparable beauty. ‘साक्षात् श्रियम् इव अपराम्’ (sākṣāt śriyam iva aparām) It seemed as though she were Lakshmi herself made manifest:

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स कदाचिन्महाराज ददर्श परमां स्त्रियम् ।
जाज्वल्यमानां वपुषा साक्षाच्छ्रियमिवापराम् ॥ २७ ॥

sa kadācin mahārāja dadarśa paramāṁ
striyam |
jājvalyamānām vapuṣā sākṣāc chriyam
ivāparām ॥ 27 ॥

(Lakshmi-like; it has also been stated this way in the Mahabharata
published by Gita Press.)

She too, upon seeing the king, became
spellbound. King Shantanu himself was radiant
and appeared like Indra, the king of the gods.
The king said to the woman, “Become my wife.”
The woman replied in her gentle voice, “I can
become your wife, but I have one condition:
Whatever I do, you must never restrain me. If
you ever do so, even by mistake, I shall leave
you.” King Shantanu accepted her condition.
Only then did he learn that the woman’s name
was Ganga.

When their first son was born, Ganga took the
child to the riverbank and immersed him in the
waters. King Shantanu had given his word that
he would not question her actions. Thereafter,
seven more sons were born, and Ganga let
each of them flow away into the river. When the
eighth son was born, the king could no longer
bear to see a child cast into the water.

Therefore, he questioned Ganga, asking why
she committed this grievous act of casting each
son into the river. Ganga said all eight of their
sons were actually the Vasus (divine beings).
They had been cursed by Sage Vashistha to
take birth on Earth and face many sufferings.

To save them from a life of pain and to give them freedom (moksha), she, Goddess Ganga, immersed them in the river right after their birth. (However, King Shantanu stopped the immersion of the eighth son, who would later become famous as Bhishma Pitamah. Due to the curse, he would be required to face many struggles and sorrows throughout his life.) Then, Ganga handed the eighth son to the king and departed. This son was also called Gangadatta.

Sometime later, King Shantanu married Satyawati, and from this union a son named Vichitravirya was born. The son of Shantanu and Satyawati, Vichitravirya, later became the father in the Kuru lineage from whom Dhritarashtra, the father of the Kauravas, descended.

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The Reason Behind Bhishma's Vow
When Bhishma was still young, his father, King Shantanu, wished to marry a young woman named Satyawati, who belonged to a lineage considered lower than that of the king. However, the Nishada chief, the foster-father of the maiden, refused the marriage on the grounds that even if a son were born to his daughter, the son would not be made king, since Bhishma, the elder son of King Shantanu, already stood first in the line of succession. Thereupon, Bhishma took a solemn vow before his father that he would never marry and would renounce all claim to the throne. In this way, he removed himself from succession and sought

the maiden from the Nishada King for his father. Thus, the father of the maiden consented, and King Shantanu married Satyawati. Later, it became known that Satyawati was in truth the daughter of King Vasu of Chedi, whom the Nishada chief had merely raised and nurtured. Pleased with the sacrifice of his son, King Shantanu granted Bhishma a boon:

“Gangadatta shall attain death only by his own will. He shall live as long as he desires.”

“Gangadatta shall possess the boon of *icchā-mṛtyu*—the power to choose the time of his own death.”

Due to this terrible and awe-inspiring vow (Bhishma *pratijñā*), King Shantanu’s son came to be known as Bhishma.

Yet, at that time, no one could have foreseen that this very boon of death-at-will would one day become one of the causes of the downfall of the Kuru kingdom. Because of this boon, Duryodhana later became so arrogant that he began to regard Bhishma Pitamaha as invincible and assumed victory in the war even before it began. Had Bhishma not bound himself to the Kuru throne in the name of duty to the state, the war might not have taken place. But the course of events is written by the Divine long in advance; therefore, He is God, for no one can fully comprehend what He has ordained.

After some time, from the womb of Satyawati, the first wise son, Chitrangada, was born. Sometime later, her second son, Vichitravirya,

was born. While Vichitravirya was still young, King Shantanu passed away. Thereafter, Prince Gangadatta (Bhishma), according to the wish of Mother Satyawati, placed Chitrangada upon the throne.

Chitrangada lived in pride of his own valor. One day, in battle with a Gandharva, he met his death.

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Bhishma's First Great Mistake (The Story of Gangadatta)

When Prince Vichitravirya came of age, Bhishma Pitamaha went to the svayamvara (the ceremony of choosing a groom) held at the court of the king of Kashi and carried away the three princesses of Kashi. Their names were Amba, Ambika, and Ambalika. At that svayamvara, Bhishma fought a fierce battle with King Shalva. King Shalva was to be married to the eldest princess, Amba.

The eldest princess came to Bhishma's palace and told him that, in her heart, she had already chosen King Shalva as her husband. Upon learning this, Bhishma granted permission to the eldest princess, Amba, to return.

Thereafter, Bhishma arranged the marriage of the remaining two princesses, Ambika and Ambalika, with his younger half-brother Vichitravirya.

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Having taken Bhishma's permission, Princess Amba went to the city of King Shalva. However, King Shalva told her, "You have already belonged to another; therefore, I have no

desire to marry a woman like you. Return to Bhishma, who carried you away.” But Amba did not return to Bhishma, thinking, “I came away from him with his own permission; with what face shall I now return to Hastinapura (the capital of the Kuru kingdom)?” Thinking thus, she left the city. Yet, she resolved in her heart: “The injustice done to me is only because of Bhishma. I must take revenge upon him.”

Amba then went to a hermitage and narrated her entire story to the ascetics residing there. Present there was her grandfather, the great ascetic Hotravahana, who accepted Amba as his own daughter. After hearing everything, he advised her to go and meet Parashurama, a sage and warrior.

After meeting Parashurama, Amba told him her entire story and prayed, “Please slay Bhishma.” Thereupon, Parashurama came to Hastinapura to fight Bhishma. When the two stood upon the battlefield, Mother Ganga came there and pleaded with Parashurama not to fight. Yet, Bhishma did not withdraw and continued to release arrows at Parashurama. For twenty-three days, Bhishma and Parashurama fought one another.

At last, Bhishma placed upon his bow an extraordinary weapon called *prasvāpanāstra*. Just as Bhishma was about to release this *prasvāpanāstra* upon Parashurama, voices arose from all directions, saying: “O Bhishma, do not release this weapon upon Parashurama. He is your guru and a knower of Brahman (*brahma-vettā*), a great Brahmin.”

Hearing this, Bhishma withdrew the prasvāpanāstra from his bow. Seeing this act of restraint, Parashurama was pleased and said, “This dull-witted one has been overcome by Bhishma.” Thus, honoring the welfare of the worlds, Bhishma and Parashurama withdrew from the battle.

Seeing all this, Amba declared, “Now I shall go to a place where I can attain the power to slay Bhishma.” Saying this, she departed to perform severe austerities. After many births, having obtained a boon from Shiva, she was reborn as Shikhandi and returned to fulfill her vow.

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The Birth of Pandu, Dhritarashtra,
and Vidura

The younger half-brother of Bhishma and the second son of King Shantanu, Vichitravirya, died prematurely at a young age. As there was no prince to inherit the throne, Mother Satyawati urged Bhishma to beget sons from the two queens. Bhishma refused, remaining faithful to his vow.

Then Mother Satyawati approached the great Sage Vyasa to obtain heirs for the kingdom through the custom of niyoga—the ancient practice by which a qualified sage is invited to beget heirs for the continuation of a royal lineage.

After the untimely death of Vichitravirya, through the niyoga of Sage Vyasa, Dhritarashtra was born from the womb of Ambika. During the act of niyoga, Ambika, out of fear, closed her eyes; therefore, though

Dhritarashtra was born, he was blind from birth. Through the same niyoga, Pandu was born from the womb of Ambalika. Seeing Vyasa, Ambalika's face had turned pale; therefore, though she bore a son, he was afflicted with weakness and jaundice from birth and was frail by nature.

Along with this, one of the maidservants, named Parashrava, was also sent to Sage Vyasa for niyoga. She remained fearless and humble; therefore, Vyasa blessed her, and from her womb was born Vidura. Vidura was highly learned and righteous; however, being the son of a maidservant through niyoga, he could not ascend the royal throne. Thus, three sons were born in the lineage of Vichitravirya: Dhritarashtra, Pandu, and Vidura. Vidura later became a minister in the court of Dhritarashtra.

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Because Bhishma was the great-grand-uncle and guardian of the royal household, all people addressed him with reverence as Pitāmaha. “Revered grandsire; the elder patriarch of the royal lineage.”

Bhishma Pitamaha raised Dhritarashtra, Pandu, and the wise Vidura as his own sons. He performed all their rites of passage and oversaw their education. In a short time, all three brothers became highly proficient in archery (dhanurveda), mace-fighting (gadāyuddha), and the use of shield and sword. Bhishma Pitamaha also instructed them in the Vedas, the Puranas, and all codes of conduct and royal etiquette.

Upon the counsel of Vidura, Bhishma Pitamaha arranged the marriage of Pandu with Princess Pritha of the Yadava prince Shurasena. At that time, in the entire world, there was no woman equal to Pritha in beauty. Pritha had earlier been adopted by King Kuntibhoja, as Shurasena had vowed even before her birth to give her to Kuntibhoja; therefore, she came to be known as Kunti.

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Along with this, Bhishma Pitamaha arranged the marriage of Dhritarashtra with Gandhari, the virtuous daughter of King Subala of Gandhara. Sometime later, Bhishma Pitamaha also arranged the marriage of Pandu with Madri, the daughter of the King of Madra.

The Birth of Karna

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Long before her marriage, Princess Pritha had been entrusted by her father King Kuntibhoja with the duty of serving guests who visited their palace. One day, the Brahmin sage, Durvasa, arrived at King Kuntibhoja's house. Sage Durvasa was of the highest spiritual stature, but his nature was extremely stern and his anger flared quickly; therefore, beings throughout the universe feared him. Pritha served him devotedly, as this duty had been assigned to her. Pleased with her service, Sage Durvasa—who could clearly perceive the future of all—foreseeing the difficulties that would befall Pritha, bestowed upon the princess a mantra of invocation and explained the complete vidhiḥ (method) for using it to uphold

righteousness. Finally, he said that by chanting this mantra, whichever deity Pritha invoked would grant her a son.